

Discussion of “**Denunciations and secret evidence**” by Giorgio Farace

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An attractively simple setup

- A **ruler** decides how to partition citizens (denunciation regime)
- **Citizens** with private benefits θ from disobedience decide whether to obey or disobey
- Ruler **im**perfectly observes misbehavior (privately)
- Citizens perfectly observe misbehavior (although tweaked at the end)
- Citizens decide who to rat out (within their partition) – each report costs ξ
- **Payoffs:**

If you misbehave and get away with it, great!

If you misbehave and get told on, not so great.

If someone else misbehaved, the ruler finds out **but you didn't tell on them**, not so great.

Some attractively (mostly) simple intuitions

- Foundational intuitions about reporting:
 - Ends up being threshold-ish: Obedient citizens report when reporting is sufficiently cheap; if *everyone* in a block disobeys and reporting is very cheap, reporting mixes
- The size of the “reporting block” (your partition) matters for two reasons
 - More people $\Rightarrow$ more potential reporters $\Rightarrow$ stronger deterrence
 - But more people $\Rightarrow$ more potential reporting **obligations** if you obey (remember, bad news if you don’t report bad people!) $\Rightarrow$ obedience becomes more costly
- Optimal block size balances these forces (modulo costs, etc)
 - If reporting is cheap and ruler is bad at monitoring, he favors larger groups – relying on citizen reporting
 - If reporting is cheap and ruler is better at monitoring, he favors smaller ones
- Many well worked-out technical results, etc. that flesh out and reinforce this
 - E.g. fun caveat: If there is instead **imperfect** peer monitoring, making reporting too cheap can actually decrease deterrence

Speculative not-quite-suggestions

- Here is an oddball idea. One thing that I feel like is integral in these kinds of situations is “**trust**” ...
- Right now, your all-disobedient case contains a Pareto-preferred pact of silence that fails bc it isn't self-enforcing. **In a repeated relationship**, could citizens sustain this kind of pact (and potentially other collusive behaviors)?
 - On one hand, this might break nice things (like threshold structures etc) since your model is already somewhat complicated
 - On the other hand, with the right fairy dust (assumptions/refinements) this could say something about instances of repression that are sort of “one-time” (sort of let 100 flowers bloom-ish) versus sustained over time
- Might caveat/break some of your current results, which would be cool, and might match empirically observable variation

Since we are at a political science conference...

- What is the core mechanism? What does it tell us about politics?
 - What is the **one really cool and new thing** that I should take away from this?
- The headline intuition is nice: Ruler can force citizens to reveal offenses that he himself missed by keeping secret which offenses he already knows about
- But what empirical settings actually give rulers discretion over the boundaries or size of reporting groups?
- My impression: in many denunciation settings, the social groups/networks (families, coworkers, ethnic/religious enclaves) are preestablished
- Struggling to think of times when they are re-conceived “from scratch” with the express (or even potential) purpose of repression
 - Maybe creation of “danwei” work-unit system during early PRC?
- “A central institutional choice is then how these groups should be formed, if at all.” What are these institutions, other than freshman dormitories (reporting alcohol abuse?) or the military

Since we are theorists after all...

- My guess is that theory readers may demand more generality and/or an obvious reason why **“this is a worthy new addition to our theory arsenal”**
 - Right now the model contains many moving parts that connect nicely, but none of them jump out to me as “the core”
- For instance, if I was a theorist thinking “how might this be useful to settings outside denunciations/secret police?” then which **features of the model** would you want me to be paying attention to?
 - If I encountered a very different application totally unlike what specific things you had in mind for this paper, what feature/result from this paper should make me think “ah, Giorgio’s paper is the right tool for this problem”?
- And whose problem is the interesting one? Right now it feels like the ruler decision is in the spotlight, but citizens’ actions are also quite rich, and feel a bit supplementary at the moment. As an “applied theory” reader I am (if anything) equally invested in citizens’ behavior in this problem

Who is the audience you want for this paper?

- I am not quite sure **who this paper is meant for**
- Right now, if I wanted to be super mean, I'd say that the model has a real-world-plausible premise, but it's not easy to map the results onto real-world-plausible implications
 - Political science speak: "What is the puzzle", what is the unexplained case, what is the thing that current theories of denunciations can't explain? Can you hit this hammer a bit harder throughout the paper?
 - Your motivating quotation is from hyper-ancient China, which is neat, but it doesn't really get carried through the paper
- If you want this to be a paper for political scientists (ymmv): You have room to relegate some of the technical pieces to the appendix, and spend the main text building out empirical implications, case studies, etc.